Repulsion: Your character finds a certain substance abhorrent. Choose this when taking the bane, but it should be something that is likely to appear in many homes. For example, garlic, salt, roses, or silver are all valid repulsions. She cannot come closer than (10 – Humanity) feet from the item without spending a point of Willpower. As well, if the object of repulsion enters a wound, it causes (10 – Humanity) dice of bashing damage.

Symbols: Symbols of faith and devotion weaken your character. When touched by such a symbol, or when acting against someone brandishing such a symbol, his dice pools are limited by his Humanity dots.

Webs: A spider's webs cause your character great problems. Even a web from a small spider stops her in her tracks. Once she touches a web, breaking free requires breaking the web, which is treated as an item with Durability equal to (10 – Humanity).

Merits

These Merits are available to Kindred characters. If the prerequisites mention a covenant, the Merit requires a single dot of the appropriate Covenant Status to purchase. If the character changes or abandons their covenant, the Merit does not go away. Some covenants may take issue with former members sharing their secrets, however. See the Appendix (p. 288) for Merits specifically for mortal and ghoul characters in a **Vampire: The Requiem** chronicle.

Sanctity of Merits

While Merits represent things within the game and your character, they're really an out-of-character resource, a function of the character creation and advancement mechanics. These Merits often represent things that can go away. Retainers can be killed. Mentors can get impatient and stop dispensing wisdom. So while Merits may represent temporary facets of your character, Merit points continue to exist. At the end of any chapter where your character has lost Merits, you can replace them with another Merit.

For example, your character has three-dot Retainer, a loyal dog, and an eldritch horror eats that dog out in the woods. At the end of that chapter, you may re-allocate those Retainer dots. You may choose to purchase Safe Place (two dots), to reflect your character's choice to bunker down from the monster, and perhaps Direction Sense (one dot) so your character is less likely to get lost in those woods in the future. When the character leaves his Safe Place, you can replace those two dots with something else.

When replacing a Merit, consider what makes sense in the story. Pursue the new Merit during the course of the chapter if possible, and make the new tie something less superficial than a dot or two on a sheet.

With Storyteller permission, you may "cash in" a Merit voluntarily and replace it with Experiences. This should not be used as a way to purchase a Merit, take advantage of its benefits, and then cash it out for something else. If a Merit has run its course and no longer makes sense for your character, however, you may use those points elsewhere.

Merits such as Ambidextrous, Eidetic Memory, and the various Fighting Style Merits reflect abilities and knowledge that your character has and therefore shouldn't be cashed in or replaced. Then again, if an Ambidextrous character loses his left hand....

General Kindred Merits

Acute Senses (•)

Effect: The vampire can see, smell, and hear at twice the distance and with twice the accuracy of an average, healthy mortal. The vampire's senses of taste and touch are also twice as sensitive as those of the same hypothetical person. The vampire can see in pitch dark.

The vampire can perfectly identify any sensory stimulus she has experienced before; for example, the smell of a lover's sweat, the texture of a rare fabric, or the sound of an individual's scream.

Add her Blood Potency to any roll to use her senses. This includes any rolls to remember and identify sensory details.

Drawback: Her senses sometimes overwhelm her. Any time you roll an exceptional success on a roll relating to her senses, she gains the Obsession Condition for the stimulus, but instead of being Persistent, it lasts for a number of nights equal to your successes.

Altar (•••)

Prerequisites: Circle of the Crone Status •

Effect: Your character is attuned to a mystical, bloody altar. She may have crafted it herself, or a covenmate may have designed it. In the presence of the altar, Acolytes may use the teamwork rules (see p. 173) when using Crúac rituals. However, double the time necessary to make the roll, and determine the time per roll by the lowest Crúac dots of the collective group. This allows vampires uninitiated in the secrets of Crúac to participate in rituals. Characters do not need dots in Crúac to act as supporting performers with the Altar Merit, but double the time between rolls if any participants have no Crúac dots whatsoever.

Drawback: Unlike most Merits, three or more characters must purchase this Merit to gain its benefits. Each character contributes a single Merit dot to the total cost. Additional characters may purchase dots in the Altar, but to use the teamwork advantages, they must contribute.

Anointed (••)

Prerequisites: Lancea et Sanctum Status •

Effect: Not all Sanctified are members of the clergy. Most are lay members. Those anointed under the damnation of Longinus

wield his word like a firebrand. Once per chapter, roll Presence + Expression when preaching to a crowd. A small clique of listeners levies a –1 die penalty, a small crowd a –2, and a large crowd a –3. Listeners gain the Raptured Condition (see p. 305).

Drawback: The character may not use this Merit on herself.

Atrocious (•)

Prerequisites: Cannot have the Cutthroat or Enticing Merits

Effect: Your character's monstrous Beast dominates her personality. Her threats always ring true. Her very gaze inspires anger and fear. Any rolls to invoke the monstrous Beast gain the 8-again quality.

Drawback: Your character does not get the 10-again quality on any rolls to invoke or resist the seductive or competitive Beasts.

Attaché (•)

Prerequisites: Invictus Status •

Effect: Normally, Retainers (see p. 123) serve a couple of functions, represented by dice pools. They don't normally allow a character to access other things represented by Social Merits. However, Invictus vampires with this Merit have Retainers of a more thoroughly loyal breed. Each Retainer gains any combination of the following Merit dots equal to the vampire's Invictus Status: Contacts, Resources, or Safe Place.

Drawback: While the Invictus may access these Merits, it must be done through an intermediary. So it might take a bit of time, or require a bit of red tape navigation to access. At very least it will require a few inconvenient phone calls.

Bloodhound (••)

Prerequisites: Wits •••

Effect: Your character can discern the intricacies of blood by smelling it, as if he had tasted it. When using his Kindred senses to detect blood, to track by blood, or to pick out the details of blood, he only needs to smell a blood source.

Cacophony Savvy (• to •••)

Prerequisite: City Status •

Effect: You have your finger on the pulse of the Kindred underground. You're adept with the codes and cants that allow Kindred culture to flourish despite the Masquerade. Each level of Cacophony Savvy builds on the previous. This Merit assumes the character can read and deliver Cacophony messages.

Drawback: The Cacophony is not a spectator sport. You can't just consume; you must create. If your character does not regularly contribute news and gossip to the Cacophony, she falls out of touch. To become an active part of the Cacophony again, she must add something of value.

Gettin' Up (•): Your character can read the signs when she sees them. With an Intelligence + Streetwise roll, she can identify the intended message. She can identify further details, including the messenger's clan, covenant, favored herd, and city of origin by taking a –1 die penalty for every detail she wishes to discern. Additional details come at Storyteller discretion.

If the area surveyed is part of someone's Feeding Grounds Merit, you can add their dot rating to your roll, and discern things the owner didn't mean to communicate. For example, particularly pale junkies in the neighborhood might suggest that the owner feeds from addicts.

Backpacker (••): Your character is privy to all the personal ads, magazine codes, tracts, and tagging locations to find the latest Kindred news. Any time new Kindred come to town, your character knows their favored feeding grounds and their common aliases within a week. Using Gettin' Up, she can discern more personal information about them from the grapevine.

Wearing a Hat (•••): Your character embodies honor among thieves. She's a highly respected part of the Cacophony, and as a result, nothing happens without her knowledge. She's a hub of local culture, and the first line of defense against vampire hunters by extension. Once per chapter, roll Wits + Politics. For each success, you can ask the Storyteller one of the following questions about the current state of affairs:

- Who is on the way up?
- Who is on the way out?
- Where in the city is the Masquerade thinnest?
- What mortal is closest to uncovering Kindred?
- Where's the best feeding in town?

When acting on the answer, consider all rolls exceptional successes on three successes instead of five.

Carthian Pull (•)

Prerequisite: Carthian Status •

Effect: Carthians know people. Being the covenant arguably most in touch with humanity, they tend to have the most numerous connections. Membership in the Movement can mean leveraging those connections. Each month, you can access a number of dots of the Allies, Contacts, Haven, and Herd Merits equal to your Carthian Status.

Drawback: These Merits are not yours. They're very temporary, very superficial. You don't get a house from Haven dots; you get crash space for a couple days. Each use is a favor, and the Movement expects members to repay their favors.

Claws of the Unholy (•)

Prerequisite: Protean ••••

Effect: A Gangrel's claws are deadly and bestial; yours are downright unnatural. The vampire allows the Beast out of its cage and lets it punish all those around her. When wielding claws borne of Unnatural Aspect while in frenzy, this Merit takes effect. The weapon modifier for the claws becomes +0 aggravated. These claws ignore all armor not generated by Resilience.

Drawback: You may only use Claws of the Unholy while in frenzy or riding the wave. Once purchased, this modification is not optional; the character manifests Claws of the Unholy any time she's frenzied.

Close Family (•)

Effect: Your character feels blood sympathy more keenly than most of her kind. Add +1 to all blood sympathy bonuses, and apply the 8-again quality to all blood sympathy rolls. As well, treat all relations as one step closer for the purposes of sympathy distances.

Drawback: When you feel sympathy, you feel it hard. Any time you succeed on a blood sympathy roll, your character loses the ability to spend Willpower for bonus dice for the remainder of the scene, due to the distraction.

Cutthroat (•)

Prerequisites: Cannot have the Atrocious or Enticing Merits

Effect: Your character's competitive Beast flows in her every action. Her smug bearing forces a desire to dominate or submit. Any rolls to invoke the competitive Beast gain the 8-again quality.

Drawback: Your character does not get the 10-again quality on any rolls to invoke or resist the monstrous or seductive Beasts.

Distinguished Palate (•)

Effect: Your character can discern the subtle nuances in blood and Vitae. Consider any Taste of Blood roll (see p. 91) an exceptional success with only a single success.

Drawback: When taking this Merit, choose a preferred feature in a vessel that comprises no more than one-tenth of the population. This may be a hair color, a blood type, or even a drug in his system. When feeding from any other mortal source, ignore the first point of Vitae ingested in a given scene, as nothing sates your character like her preferred meal.

Dream Visions (•)

Prerequisites: Must be Mekhet

Effect: Your character's Mekhet blood touches on a level of universal interconnectedness that her mind cannot truly grasp. However, sometimes it gives her fleeting glimpses of insight and intuition. During the day, she dreams of what's to come in vague symbols. Once per night, when she meets someone new or visits a new place, make a Blood Potency roll. If successful, ask one question to the Storyteller or the character's player. The question must fit with a yes/no/maybe answer. The answer reflects the last day's dreams.

Drawback: This Merit may only be used once per person (and only on first meeting), and once per night. So, if she meets multiple new people, you must choose who the dreams were of.

Dynasty Membership (• to •••)

Prerequisite: Clan Status •

Effect: Your character claims membership to a long-standing dynasty of Kindred. Her clan and city know her family's exploits, and they often precede her. Each level of this Merit builds on the earlier abilities.

Drawback: You must make your association known to take advantage of this Merit. Within certain crowds, throwing around a lineage could be more trouble than it's worth. The dynasty must have at least three members.

New Kid (•): You're recognized within the dynasty, but not in an influential position. Once per chapter, you may add the Clan Status of the dynasty's most senior member to a Social dice pool instead of your own.

Exemplar (••): You're afforded sway and respect within the dynasty. Against any who would respect or fear your dynasty, you may ignore the first Door in any Social engagement.

Patriarch/Matriarch (•••): You're acknowledged as a head of your dynasty. Once per chapter, you may make a demand of a dynasty member. They gain the Tasked Condition. If they fulfill the demand, gain a Beat. The task must be something that would take a full night's work, or put the recipient in danger.

Enticing (•)

Prerequisites: Cannot have the Atrocious or Cutthroat Merits

Effect: Your character's seductive Beast oozes with ease and confidence. Her smoky looks tantalize the imagination. Every movement of her hands makes promises. Any rolls to invoke the seductive Beast gain the 8-again quality.

Drawback: Your character does not get the 10-again quality on any rolls to invoke or resist the monstrous or competitive Beasts.

Feeding Grounds (• to •••••)

Effect: Your character has fertile feeding grounds, whether officially granted or not. Dots in this Merit represent the ease of hunting in that territory. Add the dot rating to any hunting rolls, and to starting Vitae rolls (see p. 95). In addition, add the dot rating to any predatory aura conflicts on her territory.

Drawback: Territory doesn't maintain itself. Trespassers must not go uncontested, or your hold on the area falters.

Friends in High Places •

Prerequisites: Invictus Status •

Effect: The Invictus have their fingers in a lot of pies...but any one vampire only has so many fingers. So the vampires of the First Estate do not just leverage their personal connections — they leverage each other's. An Invictus member can always do a little horse trading.

Each month, your character can automatically open a number of Doors equal to her status dots. The person being persuaded must be acting on behalf of an organization. You could persuade the fire chief not to investigate a series of arsons at your rival's havens, but couldn't convince him to give you a personal loan.

Drawback: The influence the character drew upon must come from a specific Invictus member...and your character now owes him a favor.

Haven (• to •••••)

Prerequisite: Safe Place •

Effect: A good haven is not only safe from the sun, but also familiar and comforting. The dot rating reflects your character's affinity for his home and its defenses against the sun's intrusion. A low rating might mean an unreliable apartment with boarded windows. A high rating may mean an ancestral home with no windows and an extensive system of vaults.

Add your Haven dots to any Humanity rolls to notice danger while sleeping, and any Stamina + Resolve rolls to remain awake. As well, add it to any Kindred senses (see p. 90) rolls within.

Drawback: Losing a Haven is a breaking point at Humanity 8, minus its dot rating. A Haven must be tied to a Safe Place Merit (see p. 123). Like a Safe Place, a coterie may share a Haven Merit. Each member that wishes to benefit must invest Merit dots in both the Safe Place and the Haven.

Herd (• to •••••)

Effect: Your character cultivates cliques of mortals willing and eager for the Kiss. Each week, you can draw on a number of Vitae equal to twice the Merit's dot rating. This requires no roll, only a quick interlude. Taking more than that amount requires normal hunting rolls.

Drawback: Addicts need their fix. Sometimes, they demand attention. If neglected, they'll withdraw. Your character must have at least minor interactions with her Herd before they'll give blood freely.

Honey Trap (•)

Effect: Your character's blood not only bonds, but it invigorates. When a vampire tastes your character's Vitae, she regains a point of Willpower. If this results in a new bond, or steps up an existing bond, she also takes a Beat.

Invested (•)

Prerequisite: Invictus Status •

Effect: In the Invictus, you get out what you put in. Through doing favors and making herself noticed, your character has gotten back plenty. Divide dots equal to your Invictus status in the Herd, Mentor, Resources, and Retainers Merits. You may distribute them as you like. These dots can be added to existing Merit dots, or added upon later. If she loses dots of Status, the dots granted by this Merit go away as well.

Drawback: These advantages came from the covenant. They're not only known, but they're a matter of covenant scrutiny. Rivals may call whether your character deserves them into question.

Kindred Status

Within Kindred society, there exist three types of Status: City, Clan, and Covenant. Each functions as the Status Merit on p. 123, within its purview. City Status allows its advantages within the scope of the assigned city. Clan Status only functions within its designated clan, and Covenant Status similarly within the chosen covenant.

City Status reflects a vampire's sway in the city, whether official or unofficial. There's no specific dot rating tied to a given position. For instance, a Prince may have three dots of City Status, if the city doesn't respect his authority as much as the Sheriff with five dots.

Clan Status reflects notoriety and recognition within the clan. Typically, a character with high Clan Status is iconic within the clan. A character with five dots of Ventrue Status is whom most Kindred think of when they speak of the clan Ventrue. Kindred recognize a low-Status character as a frequent collaborator within clan circles.

A character may not gain Status in a clan to which she does not belong.

Covenant Status is generally tied to positions and direct authority within covenant structure. A character with five dots of Covenant Status is a regional leader within the covenant, a character with one dot has minor responsibilities to their organization of choice. Additionally, each covenant has available Merits that scale depending on Covenant Status dots.

A character could theoretically gain Status within multiple covenants. Most of the covenants will allow members to dabble in other organizations, so long as they don't share secrets. The Ordo Dracul, for example, will not stop a member from attending Sanctified mass. But the moment she shares her knowledge of the Coils, she'll find her Requiem cut abruptly short. Her combined dots in one type of Status (City, Clan, or Covenant) cannot exceed five, and she may never have as many dots in her affiliated group as she does to the group to which she belongs.

Kiss of the Succubus (•)

Prerequisite: Must be Daeva

Effect: All Kindred can evoke lustful, passionate reactions with a bite. The Daeva's bite is downright addicting. Her Kiss causes the Addicted Condition in mortals as well as the Swooning Condition (for Addicted, see p. 301; for Swooning, see p. 306).

Drawback: This gift is a double-edged sword. On one hand, it keeps blood dolls coming back. On the other, they won't stay away.

Lineage (•)

Prerequisite: Clan Status •

Effect: You come from strong stock. Your sire's well known, and his influence bleeds onto your interactions. Once per chapter, this Merit can represent a single dot of one of the following Merits: Allies, Contacts, Mentor, Resources, or Status. The Merit must be one your sire may have possessed.

Drawback: Calling on your sire's reputation taxes his social capital. He may ask for repayment for using his name.

Lorekeeper (•)

Prerequisites: Lancea et Sanctum Status •

Effect: The Spear is tasked with the acquisition and maintenance of history and mystical secrets. Most devoted members of the covenant establish and maintain libraries. Since most of this knowledge has to pass through mortal hands, the Sanctum also tends to attract those, likeminded, who wish to surround themselves with ancient secrets. When a member of the Lancea et Sanctum with this Merit buys the Library Merit (see p. 121), she also receives dots in the Retainers and Herd Merits, divided however she chooses.

Drawback: The Retainers and Herd afforded by this Merit are drawn in by the lure of forbidden knowledge. To maintain these advantages, the vampire must be willing to let slip at least some of that information to her mortal retinue. Unfortunately, sometimes mortal librarians aren't quite as zealous about defending their secrets.

The Mother-Daughter Bond (•)

Prerequisites: Circle of the Crone Status •

Effect: The Circle exists through tribulation and mentorship. Without tight-knit bonds, the Circle would never have survived its tumultuous early years. When a member of the Circle with this Merit purchases the Mentor Merit, that Mentor is protected by the True Friend Merit (see p. 124). The vampire does not have to purchase True Friend to take this advantage.

Drawback: Strong bonds go both ways. The mentor is likely to have stronger requirements than most teachers, and will require a substantial amount of the vampire's time. More importantly, she'll demand loyalty, if not monogamy.

Night Doctor Surgery (•••)

Prerequisite: Carthian Status ••

Effect: Carthians have adapted a bit of real-world surgery and a little body horror into a series of morbid reconstruction techniques to help injured Kindred heal. Night Doctor Surgery helps bones reset, and speeds the knitting of flesh. With an hour of treatment, roll Intelligence + Medicine. Each success converts one point of lethal damage to bashing. Alternatively, three successes can convert one point of aggravated damage to lethal damage. Failure means the wounds remain; dramatic failure upgrades three points of bashing to lethal, or two lethal to aggravated. With Storyteller discretion, this Merit and Willpower expenditure may be used over time to make changes to facial appearance.

Drawback: Knowledge of Night Doctor Surgery affords a great responsibility. If your identity is known, the Movement will call on your services frequently. For this reason, most Night Doctors use pseudonyms (usually a letter, like Doctor H), performing their services while masked. You cannot perform

Night Doctor Surgery on yourself. You may only make one attempt to treat a given injury.

Speaker for the Silent (•••)

Prerequisite: Dynasty Membership •, Invictus Status •

Effect: Any Kindred may be part of a dynastic house, but the Invictus take dynasty membership very seriously. Some members receive training to channel the minds of torpid dynasty members. With this Merit, the character can choose to act as a medium for a torpid elder's consciousness. While possessed, the Speaker is aware of what occurs around him, but the torpid Kindred has control of his body, and can speak through him. The torpid Kindred retains no access to her Disciplines while possessing a Speaker. At any time, the Speaker can spend a point of Willpower to eject the torpid mind. The torpid Kindred can relinquish her control at will.

Pack Alpha (•)

Prerequisite: Must be Gangrel

Effect: You're pack-minded. Your blood draws to blood. You may designate a coterie of Kindred and ghouls as your pack. Every Gangrel has a different method for the designation. Some anoint with blood. Some have hazing rituals. When the pack takes teamwork actions, the supporting characters gain the 8-again quality on their rolls. The anchor character does not, but still adds dice equal to the others' successes.

Removing a pack member must be done by force. You must cause lethal damage in one of their last three Health boxes, then exile them from your presence for at least a week.

Drawback: When a member of your pack defies you, you must make an example of them or lose a point of Willpower.

Unnatural Affinity (• to •••••)

Effect: Your character can take nourishment from the blood of some of the stranger creatures of the World of Darkness. Each dot of this Merit allows your character to gain sustenance from one type of supernatural creature. This may mean werewolves, ghosts, mummies, zombies, or stranger things still. This blood counts as Kindred Vitae for the purposes of feeding restrictions.

Drawback: This advantage does not inherently mean the character is (more) able to feed from the chosen subject. For example, ghosts exist in an ethereal state, and don't have physical blood. Werewolves are notoriously difficult to feed from for more practical reasons that often end in Final Death. If you take this Merit, work with your Storyteller to determine how your character might feed from these monsters.

Swarm Form (••)

Prerequisite: Protean •••

Effect: When taking the Beast's Skin, some Gangrel can instead become a swarm of small creatures: Size 0 or Size 1 animals. The character may perceive through any of the senses of any individual creature in the swarm, but the swarm acts as a single entity.

The swarm may spread over five yards or meters per dot of Blood Potency. Creatures beyond that range die and rapidly decompose. The swarm moves at the vampire's Speed, modified for the creatures' Size, in any logical direction.

The swarm limits visibility and hearing, and causes panic in all those present. Everyone within the swarm's area suffers the persistent Distracted Condition (see p.302) until they get away. With Storyteller discretion, a swarm may have other features suited to the swarm animal. For example, rats should be better at biting through barricades.

The swarm resists most harm. Roll attacks against the swarm as normal, but after factoring armor and other modifiers, the swarm only takes one point of damage of the appropriate type at most, or two points of damage with an exceptional success. Fire, sunlight, explosions, and other large-scale threats cause normal harm to the swarm, which is affected by banes as normal. To attack those within her swarm, roll Strength + Brawl, ignoring Defense. Divide the damage however you wish among those inside. Apply a victim's armor to the damage normally. The damage is lethal (bashing to Kindred). Alternately, a success may instead allow the vampire to take one Vitae from a victim.

Secret Society Junkie (•)

Prerequisites: Ordo Dracul Status •

Effect: The Ordo Dracul exist within one of the most secret of secret societies. But many of its members participate in other such organizations in mortal (or other) spheres. Members of such secret societies tend to draw toward the Dragon, like a moths to a flame. When the vampire takes Status or Mystery Cult Initiation (see p. 121) reflecting non-Kindred organizations, she also gains Herd dots equal to the Merit.

Sworn (•)

Prerequisites: Ordo Dracul Status •

Effect: Your character is not only a member of the Ordo Dracul, she's sworn to serve one of its branches. When taking this Merit, choose to which faction she belongs (the Axe, the Dying Light, or Mysteries typically). She gains dots equal to her Covenant Status to split between the Mentor and Retainer Merits. These reflect teachers and wards within the faction. She can swap these Merits out between chapters, as she receives new assignments.

Sworn of the Axe must defend the sanctity of the Order's secrets. They're the soldiers and assassins expected to clean up any leaks. If a Dragon leaks knowledge of the Coils, they can expect a visit from the Sworn of the Axe.

Sworn of the Dying Light act as the research and development wing of the Ordo Dracul. The Sworn dedicate themselves to learning, teaching, and creating Coils.

Sworn of the Mysteries are the guiding hands of the Order as a whole. They make sweeping decisions determining the

covenant's political and social directions. They're expected to know the affairs of all local chapter houses.

Drawback: Being Sworn is no easy task. It means being tied inexorably to the covenant, with deep and time-demanding responsibilities. Your character cannot go two full nights without devoting at least some time to covenant affairs, or she'll be punished.

I Know a Guy (•)

Prerequisites: Carthian Status •

Effect: When Carthians make Allies (see p. 118), their covenant acts as a sort of support network that bolsters the efficiency of those allies. Once per story, a Carthian may access temporary Retainer dots equal to their Allies. These Retainers act in the Carthian's interest, just like any other Retainers. (Since Allies gained with Carthian Pull don't really belong to the character as a Merit, they don't count for purposes of I Know A Guy.)

Drawback: These Retainers represent the Allies group in question, and will serve its interests first and foremost. If the Carthian wants them to do something contrary to the group's interest, she'll need to manipulate, threaten, or otherwise risk her relationship with her Allies.

Touchstone (• to •••••)

Effect: Your character has multiple Touchstones. Each dot in the Touchstone Merit allows for an additional Touchstone. Look to the Touchstone chart for which Humanity dot each new Touchstone is applied to. For more on Touchstones, see p. 87.

Drawback: Losing attachment with Touchstones will speed the loss of Humanity. As well, if your character's last Touchstone dies or is destroyed, your character will feel the call of torpor.

Undead Menses (••)

Effect: Throughout history, various cultures attributed mystical significance to the menstrual cycle. Many of these myths carried stigmas against menses, due to the unhealthy fears of men in power.

With this Merit, your character still produces menstrual blood. Once per night, she can produce a viscous, dark blood. If she uses this blood in casting a Crúac ritual, she benefits from the 8-again quality. If she touches it to a person before affecting them with a Discipline, they suffer her Blood Potency as a penalty to their Resistance.

Drawback: The character must identify as female. If she draws forth her Undead Menses multiple times in an evening, each beyond the first causes her a level of aggravated damage. As well, any attempts to identify her by her menstrual blood gain a +5 die bonus.

Multiple Touchstones

Touchstone Merit	Associated Humanity
0 dots	6
•	5
••	4
•••	3
••••	2
•••••	1

Unsettling Gaze (•)

Prerequisites: Must be Nosferatu

Effect: All Haunts have an unsettling effect. Your character's Beast oozes with terror. When she evokes the monstrous Beast (see p. 91), she unsettles her target deeply and makes him question himself. Any time she infects a victim with the Bestial Condition and scores an exceptional success, she also forces a breaking point if the victim has a higher Humanity (or Integrity) than hers.

Drawback: Forcing a breaking point in another is also a breaking point for your character if her Humanity is 3 or higher.

Where the Bodies Are Buried ••

Prerequisites: Invictus Status ••

Effect: The Conspiracy of Silence covers up a lot of secrets... and your character's been quietly keeping track. A number of times equal to your Invictus Status per story, you can ask one of the following questions about another vampire whose name and covenant affiliation you know:

- Who would this vampire run to if he were in trouble?
- Who is this vampire's most frequent vessel?
- What is this vampire's main source of income?
- Who is this vampire's closest living family member?
- Has this vampire covered up the murder of a human?

Drawback: Digging into this information attracts attention. At least one fellow member of the Invictus will know you were investigating the vampire.

Carthian Law

Carthian Law Merits stand as the Carthian Movement's edge in Kindred society. Each affords the Carthian certain advantages pertaining to the recognized law of the city. In many cases, this law did not come from the Carthians, but that doesn't mean they can't use it to their advantage. Carthian Law gives Kindred law a sort of metaphysical weight which prevents a city's residents from breaching protocol. Carthians have learned to leverage that, making them valuable to even cities without a Carthian government.

Lex Terrae (••)

Prerequisites: Carthian Status ••, Feeding Ground •

Effect: Territory is bond. Feeding ground is sacrosanct. Any blood poached from your character's Feeding Ground is tainted for Kindred she has not specifically allowed. When next a poacher sleeps, the blood dissolves in his gullet. When he wakes, he violently retches, taking one bashing damage per Vitae lost. As well, his lips and mouth stain with black streaks that paint him as a poacher. These marks last for one week.

Drawback: This Merit requires a clearly-defined and publicly announced feeding ground.

Mandate from the Masses (•••••)

Prerequisites: Carthian Status •••••

Effect: Carthians wield consensus the way a cop wields a baton. With the power of the Movement behind her, a ranking Carthian can call on the will of her people to strike weakness into the Movement's opposition. With her words and the mandate, she strips a Kindred enemy's blood down to nothingness. To enact this law, your character must make a clear and direct admonishment against one of the Movement's enemies. Cross a dot of Willpower off the Carthian's sheet. She must also garner the support of others of the Movement for a vote — from both Storyteller characters and players' characters. If the vote favors the admonishment, add the total dots of Carthian Status in support (including the user's five). For every five dots, reduce the victim's Blood Potency by one dot. If this reduces him to zero dots, he effectively becomes a revenant (see p. 94 for rules on revenants).

Drawback: The Willpower dot (belonging to the vampire who invoked the mandate) and Blood Potency (belonging to the victim) only come back if the victim flees the city or meets Final Death. If the Carthian meets Final Death, the victim immediately regains his lost Blood Potency. A single vampire may only be victim to one instance of this Merit at a time.

Right of Return (••)

Prerequisites: Carthian Status ••, City Status •

Effect: This somewhat rare Merit allows a Carthian to work within another covenant without fear of her covenant's ostracism. After all, Carthians aim for human solutions, and nothing is more human than the ability to adapt and socialize.

With this Merit, the character's Carthian Status does not count toward her normal limitations on multiple Covenant Status Merits. She can have as many as five dots of the Covenant Status Merit, not counting her Carthian Status. While individual characters may oppose your character's cosmopolitan membership practices, she's adept at defending them. In any Social Maneuvering with members of a covenant she claims Status in, treat her impressions as one step better (see p. 173 for more on Social Actions).

Drawback: Kindred remain ever paranoid, particularly with a Carthian in their midst. Every step she takes receives the utmost scrutiny. Your character loses the 10-again quality on rolls to hide suspicious behavior from members of her other covenants.

Strength of Resolution (•)

Prerequisites: Carthian Status •

Effect: A Carthian stands resolute in the face of that which would force her to violate the law. Add her Carthian Status to any dice pool to contest a Discipline or other supernatural power which would coax her to violate acknowledged city law.

Plausible Deniability (••••)

Prerequisites: Carthian Status •••

Effect: Carthians don't break laws; they defy laws. Influential Carthians can throw law to the wind, then laugh it off with an argument about the definition of the word "is." Any attempt to use a Discipline or other supernatural power to prove your character's guilt in breach of city law or Tradition automatically fails. She cannot be forced to confess by any means, and attempts to detect her honesty through mundane means suffer her Carthian Status as a penalty. She exhibits no stains on her aura from diablerie.

Drawback: It's one thing to deny the truth. It's another to deny the truth to witnesses. You lose the ability to use your City Status and Carthian Status dots in any Social rolls against anyone who knows for certain of your character's guilt, and opposes her.

Invictus Oaths

Invictus Oaths are the First Estate's ace in the hole, its way of establishing and maintaining a rigid and effective hierarchy. An Invictus Notary officiates Oaths; a character with the Notary Merit can preside over any Oath, so long as the participants meet the prerequisites for the Merit. Recognized and manumitted Invictus must have at least one active Oath. This is to say Invictus require the presence of a Notary for their induction.

Each Oath is a two-way street, with two active participants: the liege and vassal. The vassal must purchase the Oath Merit to gain its advantages; the liege does not. When swearing an Oath, the participants must define terms in addition to the Oath's effects. Usually, they swear for a finite time, often a year and a day. Terms include conditions for violation, which end the contract (and the Oath's effects) immediately. Unless otherwise noted, the vassal does not have to be Invictus; in fact, most are not. In rare cases, ghouls or other mortals enter Oaths. Most Notaries refuse to preside over such agreements.

Typically, Oaths are temporary. Merit dots revert when the Oath ends; see The Sanctity of Merits on p. 109.

Notary (••)

Prerequisites: Invictus Status •••

Effect: The Invictus appointed your character a Notary, a scholar of Oaths. She presides over Oath agreements. Because of your standing as an arbiter of the status quo, Invictus may not use their Invictus Status in rolls against you. As well, each

month, you may request access to a single dot of Allies, Contacts, Herd, Mentor, or Resources, granted by the covenant at large.

Drawback: Invictus are deathly serious about the sanctity of Oaths. If you're caught knowingly administering an unwilling Oath, or Oath a non-Invictus as liege in an agreement, the Invictus will remove you from the Estate. Usually, this removal comes through Final Death.

Oath of Action (••••)

Effect: With this Oath, a vassal swears to perform a service to his liege. The service must be a difficult task with definite criteria for accomplishment or failure. At the time of the swearing, both parties agree upon one of the liege's Disciplines. The vassal gains access to that Discipline. The liege's Blood Potency increases by one. This Oath stands as a rare exception to bloodline Disciplines: a vassal may temporarily access a liege's bloodline gift.

If the vassal accomplishes the task, the Oath ends and the liege suffers aggravated damage equal to the Discipline dots granted. If the vassal fails the task or a month passes, he suffers the damage instead. While not uncommon, some domains consider a liege's interference in the task to be bad form. The liege does not lose access to the Disicpline.

Drawback: A character may be part of only one Oath of Action at a time, as vassal or liege.

Oath of Fealty (•)

Prerequisites: Invictus Status •

Effect: This most basic Oath establishes a foundation of trust within the Invictus. The vassal may draw a number of Vitae from his liege equal to his Invictus Status in a given week. This Vitae transfers mystically over any distance, and replenishes the vassal's pool without risk of Vitae addiction or blood bond. The liege always knows if the vassal lies to her, in voice or in writing.

Drawback: A vassal may only owe fealty to one liege.

Oath of Penance (•••)

Effect: This Oath is a form of apology from a vassal to an aggrieved liege. For the agreed-upon term, the liege receives every tenth Vitae the vassal ingests. This Vitae comes over any distance, without risk of blood bond or addiction, and counts as Kindred Vitae. Some ancient Invictus use this Oath to skirt their need for Kindred blood, by establishing massive networks of "punished" vassals. During the same period, the vassal becomes immune to the liege's Discipline effects.

Drawback: While a vassal is paying penance, she may not gain the benefits of any other Oath. She retains their drawbacks.

Oath of Serfdom (••)

Effect: This Oath is a contract between a landlord and a tenant. In Invictus domains, Princes often use this Oath as the go-to for granting territory. Young Invictus refer to this practice as "castling." Oath of Serfdom agreements typically involve "red rent," a certain blood tithe given to the landlord regularly.

While in her granted land or when defending her liege, the vassal gains access to a dot of Celerity, Resilience, or Vigor, chosen at the swearing of the Oath. She must still pay relevant activation costs. As well, she instinctively knows when another creature with the predatory aura enters her territory, and from what direction. If she knows the trespasser, she can identify him. The liege gains the vassal's Feeding Ground Merit dots in any rolls against her. As well, he becomes immune to blood bonds from the vassal.

Kindred Fighting Merits

The Danse Macabre provides mechanisms to avoid overt violence between Kindred. However, even the most civilized Kindred cities are far deadlier than their mortal counterparts. Despite a façade of nicety, Kindred society holds numerous violent traditions. From the Invictus rite of Monomacy, to a Carthian jumping in ceremony, violence is far more commonplace than anyone wants to admit.

These Merits reflect specific tricks vampires developed to kill one another efficiently.

Kindred Dueling (Style, • to •••••)

Prerequisites: Composure •••, Weaponry ••

Effect: Your character is not only a competent fighter, but also one trained specifically to take advantage of Kindred variables in a fight. Use of Kindred dueling requires an edged weapon. While humans could theoretically learn some of these tricks, the practical experience required could prove deadly. Note that Kindred Dueling abilities may not be used together. If you're using Hamstring, you cannot benefit from Carving as well.

Hamstring (•): With a well-placed tendon strike, you can briefly cripple a vampire's ability to augment their physical prowess with Vitae. By targeting a limb (and taking the penalty to do so), your successful strike can deny that limb from the benefits of Physical Intensity (see p. 91) for a turn. The rest of the body may still use those advantages.

Taunt (••): You know the way the Beast works, and how to taunt it with short, shallow swipes. Before you roll, remove a number of dice from your pool no greater than your Weaponry dots. Make your roll. If the attack succeeds, the victim must roll to resist frenzy, with a penalty equal to the number of dice you removed.

Carving (•••): When you strike, you curve the blade hard and strike to pull the flesh apart, making it harder to heal in the heat of the moment. When Carving, your weapon's damage rating deals lethal damage to Kindred instead of bashing.

Pincushion (••••): You hit deep, intending to lodge your weapon in its victim. If you choose to leave your weapon in the victim on a successful strike, the victim cannot heal the wound with Vitae. You may remove the weapon as a reflexive action. If anyone else wishes to remove it, he can attempt a Strength + Stamina roll, minus the damage caused, as an instant action.

Spray (•••••): You cut to remove mass from the body, and by extension, blood. Sacrifice your Defense for the turn to use this maneuver. On a successful attack roll, you can choose to remove Vitae from your opponent instead of Health levels. You can divide Health levels of damage and Vitae in any combination after the roll.

Riding the Wave (Style, • to •••••)

Prerequisites: Composure •••, Resolve •••

Effect: Your character runs with her Beast, and knows how to use it to her advantage. She's turned riding the wave into a raw, primal art. These maneuvers may only be used while riding the wave. They cannot be used in a normal frenzy, or outside of frenzy.

Ravage (•): Due to your character's connection to her Beast, her fangs become horrendous weapons. They look no different, but her Beast knows how to use them with the utmost efficiency. While riding the wave, they become 1L weapons when used in a bite attack.

Primal Strength (••): Your character's Beast blasts outward in short bursts, in order to accomplish quick feats of strength. When lifting, jumping, or destroying objects as an instant action, double the Strength bonus aquired while in frenzy.

In the Zone (•••): When attempting to leash the Beast and ride the wave, your character still operates at peak efficiency. She still has to spend Willpower points in order to make rolls to ride the wave, but those Willpower points also give a +3 die bonus to any action taken in the turn.

Unyielding (••••): Your character rides the wave frequently; it ceases to be taxing on her mental reserves. After a scene where she successfully rides the wave, she recovers any Willpower spent to initiate the ride.

Animal Grace (•••••): Your character dodges and strikes as fluidly as an animal, with confidence and awareness. When spending Willpower to attack or defend, gain both benefits. Add a +2 die bonus to Defense, and a +3 die bonus to attack rolls.

Human Merits

Any vampire can possess these Merits, but they're also available to and relatively common choices for players portraying mortal characters.

For additional Merits available to all characters, see **The World of Darkness Rulebook** or **The God-Machine Chronicle**.

For Merits specific to mortals and ghouls, see p. 298.

Allies (• to •••••)

Effect: Allies help your character. They might be friends, employees, associates, or people your character has blackmailed. Each instance of this Merit represents one type of ally. This could be an individual, or the members of an organization, society, or clique. Examples include a covenant, the police, a secret society, organized crime, unions, local politics, and the academic community. Each purchase has its own rating. Your character might have Allies (Masons) ••, Allies (Carter Crime Family) •••, Allies (Carthian Movement) ••••, and Allies (Catholic Church) •.

Each dot represents a layer of influence in the group. One dot would constitute small favors and passing influence. Three could offer considerable influence, such as the overlooking of a misdemeanor charge by the police. Five dots allows favors that stretch the limits of the organization's influence, as its leaders put their own influence on the line for the character. This could include things such as ignoring massive insider trading or fouling up a felony investigation. No matter the request, it has to be something that organization could accomplish.

The Storyteller assigns a rating between one and five to any favor asked. A character can ask for favors that add up to her Allies rating without penalty in one chapter. If she extends her influence beyond that, her player must roll Manipulation + Persuasion + Allies, with a penalty equal to the favor's rating. If the roll is successful, the group does as requested. Whether the roll fails or succeeds, the character loses a dot of Allies. This dot may return at the end of the chapter. On a dramatic failure, the organization resents her and seeks retribution. On an exceptional success, she doesn't lose the dot even temporarily.

One additional favor a character can ask of her Allies is to block another character's Allies, Contacts, Mentor, Retainer, or Status (if she knows the character possesses the relevant Merit). The rating is equal to the Merit dots blocked. As before, no roll is necessary unless the target's Merit exceeds the character's Allies. If the block succeeds, the blocked character cannot use the Merit during the same chapter.

Alternate Identity (•, ••, or •••)

Effect: Your character has established an alternate identity. The level of this Merit determines the amount of scrutiny it can withstand. At one dot, the identity is superficial and unofficial. For example, your character uses an alias with a simple costume and adopts an accent. She hasn't established the necessary paperwork to even approach a bureaucratic background check, let alone pass. At two dots, she's supported her identity with paperwork and identification. It's not liable to stand up to extensive research, but it'll turn away private investigators and internet hobbyists. At three dots, the identity can pass thorough inspection. The identity has been deeply entrenched in relevant databases, with subtle flourishes and details to make it seem real even to trained professionals.

The Merit also reflects time the character has spent honing the persona. At one or two dots, she gains a +1 die bonus to all Subterfuge rolls to defend the identity. At three dots, she gains a +2 die bonus.

This Merit can be purchased multiple times, each time representing an additional identity.

Anonymity (• to •••••)

Prerequisites: Cannot have Fame

Effect: Your character lives off the grid. She could have been dead for decades, making new identification difficult. This means purchases must be made with cash or falsified credit

cards. She avoids any official authoritative influence in her affairs. Any attempts to find her by paper trail suffer a –1 die penalty per dot purchased in this Merit.

Drawback: Your character cannot purchase the Fame Merit. This also may limit Status purchases, if the character cannot provide sufficient identification for the roles she wishes to take.

Area of Expertise (•)

Prerequisite: Resolve •• and one Skill Specialty

Effect: Your character is uncommonly specialized in one area. Choose a Specialty to assign to this Merit. Forgo the +1 die bonus afforded by a Specialty in exchange for a +2 die bonus.

Barfly (••)

Prerequisite: Socialize ••

Effect: Your character is a natural in the Rack and can procure an open invitation wherever she wishes. Whereas most characters would require rolls to blend into social functions they don't belong in, she doesn't; she belongs. Subtract her Socialize from any rolls to identify her as an outsider.

Contacts (•)

Effect: Contacts provide your character with information. This Merit can be taken multiple times; each instance represents a sphere or organization with which the character can garner information. For example, a character with three dots of Contacts might have Bloggers, Drug Dealers, and Vampire Hunters for connections. Contacts do not provide services, only information. This may be face-to-face, by email or telephone, or even by séance in some strange instances.

Garnering information via Contacts requires a Manipulation + Social Skill roll, depending on the method the character uses. The Storyteller should give a bonus or penalty to the roll, depending on the following factors: how relevant the information is to that particular Contact, whether accessing the information is dangerous, and whether the character has maintained good relations with or done favors for the Contact. These modifiers should range from a –3 die penalty to a +3 die bonus in most cases. If successful, the Contact provides the information.

One use of a Contact is to dig up dirt on another character. A Contact can find another character's Social Merits and any relevant Conditions.

If someone attempts to block Contacts with the Allies Merit, add up all Contacts dots to determine the effective rating, to a maximum of five.

Double Jointed (••)

Prerequisite: Dexterity •••

Effect: Your character might have been a contortionist or spent time practicing yoga. She can dislodge joints when need

be. She automatically escapes from any mundane bonds without a roll. When grappled, subtract her Dexterity from any rolls to overpower her as long as she's not taking any aggressive actions.

Etiquette (• to •••••)

Prerequisites: Composure •••, Socialize ••

Your character knows her way around society, customs, and traditions. More importantly, she can use this talent to make or break reputations. This Merit applies to any social interactions where etiquette, style, poise, and reputation carry weight, and uses the Social Maneuvering rules on p. 173.

Bless His Heart (•): Your character's words are always well-considered. No matter how vile, the things she says come off as defensible and respectful. When a character engages yours in a Social interaction, you may opt to use your character's Socialize score instead of the lower of her Resolve and Composure to determine her starting Doors.

Losing Your Religion (••): When your character lets loose and insults someone, she leaves mouths agape. When tearing down a target verbally, use 8-again, and take a +2 die bonus to the roll. Afterwards, move the interaction one step down on the impressions chart.

In High Cotton (•••): Your character cultivates standing and respect, and carries it like a knight wears armor. You may apply one relevant Status or Fame Merit to rolls to contest Social interactions. Other Merits may apply with Storyteller permission.

Half-Cocked (••••): Your character is always prepared. On the other hand, others are not. In a new Social interaction, if the impression is good, excellent, or perfect, ignore the subject's Resolve and Composure on the first roll.

Grace Under Fire (•••••): While your character may not always win, she never looks bad. If a character opens all her Doors, and you opt to offer an alternative, his player chooses three Conditions. You choose which one your character receives.

Fame (• to •••)

Effect: Your character is recognized within a certain sphere for a certain skill, or because of some past action, or just a stroke of luck. This can mean favors and attention, but it can also mean negative attention and scrutiny. This can tax the Masquerade if one's not careful. When choosing the Merit, define what your character is known for. One dot reflects local recognition or reputation within a confined subculture. Two dots means regional recognition by a wide swath of people. Three dots means worldwide recognition to anyone who might have been exposed to the source of the fame. Each dot adds a die to any Social rolls among those who are impressed by your character's celebrity.

Drawback: Any rolls to find or identify the character enjoy a +1 die bonus per dot of the Merit. If the character has Alternate Identity, she can mitigate this drawback. A character with Fame cannot have the Anonymity Merit.

Fast-Talking (• to •••••)

Prerequisites: Manipulation •••, Subterfuge ••

Your character talks circles around listeners. She speaks a mile a minute and often leaves her targets reeling, but nodding in agreement.

Always Be Closing (•): With the right leading phrases, your character can direct a mark to say what she wants, when she wants. This trips the mark into vulnerable positions. When a mark contests or resists your character's Social interactions, apply a –1 die penalty to his Resolve or Composure.

Jargon (••): Your character confuses her mark using complex terminology. You may apply one relevant Specialty to any Social roll you make, even if the Specialty isn't tied to the Skill in use.

Devil's Advocacy (•••): Your character often poses arguments she doesn't agree with in order to challenge a mark's position and keep him from advancing discussion. You can reroll one failed Subterfuge roll per scene.

Salting (••••): Your character can position herself so a mark pursues a non-issue or something unimportant to her. When your character opens a Door using conversation (Persuasion, Subterfuge, Empathy, etc.) you may spend a Willpower point to immediately open another Door.

Patron's Privilege (•••••): Your character can take advantage of her mark's greed or zeal. When the mark does particularly well, it's because your character was there to set him up and to subsequently tear him down. If a target regains Willpower from his Vice or Dirge while your character is present, you may immediately roll Manipulation + Subterfuge to open a Door, regardless of the interval or impression level.

Fleet of Foot (• to •••)

Prerequisite: Athletics ••

Effect: Your character is remarkably quick and runs far faster than her frame suggests. She gains +1 Speed per dot; anyone pursuing her suffers a –1 die penalty per dot to any foot chase rolls.

Hobbyist Clique (••)

Prerequisite: Membership in a clique. All members must possess this Merit and the chosen Skill at ••+

Effect: Your character is part of a group of hobbyists that specializes in one area, as represented by a Skill. It may be a book club, a coven, a political party, or any other interest. Many Kindred choose to cultivate this group as a Herd as well (see p. 112). When the group's support is available, you benefit from the 9-again quality on rolls involving the group's chosen Skill. As well, the clique offers a +2 die bonus on any extended actions involving that Skill.

Drawback: This Merit requires upkeep. You must attend at least monthly, informal meetings to maintain the benefits of Hobbyist Clique.

Indomitable (••)

Prerequisite: Resolve •••

Your character possesses an unyielding will. The powers of the supernatural have little bearing on her behavior. She can stand up to Kindred Dominate, a witch's charms, or a ghost's gifts of fright. Any time a supernatural creature uses a power to influence your character's thoughts or emotions, add a +2 die bonus to the dice pool to contest it. If the roll is resisted, instead subtract a –2 die penalty from the monster's dice pool. Note that this only affects mental influence and manipulation from a supernatural origin. A vampire with a remarkable Manipulation + Persuasion score is just as likely to convince your character to do something using mundane tricks.

Inspiring (•••)

Prerequisite: Presence •••

Effect: Your character's passion inspires those around her to greatness. With a few words, she can redouble a group's confidence or move them to action.

Make a Presence + Expression roll. A small clique of listeners levies a –1 die penalty, a small crowd a –2, and a large crowd a –3. Listeners gain the Inspired Condition. The character may not use this Merit on herself.

Interdisciplinary Specialty (•)

Prerequisite: Skill at ••• or higher with a Specialty

Effect: Choose a Specialty that your character possesses when you purchase this Merit. You can apply the +1 die bonus from that Specialty on any Skill with at least one dot, provided it's justifiable within the scope of the fiction. For example, a doctor with a Medicine Specialty in Anatomy may be able to use it when targeting a specific body part with Weaponry, but could not with a general strike.

Iron Will (••)

Prerequisite: Resolve ••••

Effect: Your character's resolve is unwavering. When spending Willpower to contest or resist in a Social interaction, you may substitute your character's Resolve for the usual Willpower bonus. If the roll is contested, roll with 8-again.

Language (•)

Effect: Your character is skilled with an additional language beyond her native tongue. Choose a language each time you buy this Merit. Your character can speak, read, and write in that language.

Library (• to •••)

Effect: Your character has access to a plethora of information about a given topic. When purchasing this Merit, choose a Mental Skill. The Library covers that purview. On any extended roll involving the Skill in question, add the dots in this Merit. This Merit can be purchased multiple times to reflect different Skills. Its benefits can be shared by various characters with permission.

Mentor (• to •••••)

Effect: This Merit gives your character a teacher who provides advice and guidance. He acts on your character's behalf, often in the background and sometimes without your character's knowledge. This may be a sire, a covenant leader, or other figure. While Mentors can be highly competent, they almost always want something in return for their services. The dot rating determines the Mentor's capabilities, and to what extent he'll aid your character.

When establishing a Mentor, determine what the Mentor wants from your character. The dot rating chosen should reflect the importance of the objective to him. A one-dot Mentor might be incapable of dealing with modern society and wants to live vicariously through your character. This might mean coming to him and telling stories of your character's exploits. A five-dot Mentor would want something beyond price, such as an oath to procure an ancient, cursed artifact that may or may not exist in order to prevent his prophesized death.

Choose three Skills the Mentor possesses. You can substitute Resources for one of these Skills. Once per session, the character may ask her Mentor for a favor. The favor must involve one of those Skills or be within the scope of his Resources. The Mentor commits to the favor (often asking for a commensurate favor in return); and if a roll is required on the Mentor's part to secure the favor, he is automatically considered to have successes equal to his dot rating. Alternately, the player may ask the Storyteller to have the Mentor act on her character's behalf, without her character knowing or initiating the request.

Mystery Cult Initiation (• to •••••)

Cults are far more common than the people of the World of Darkness would like to admit. Mystery cult is the catch-all term for a phenomenon ranging from secret societies couched in fraternity houses and scholarly cabals studying the magic of classical symbolism to mystical suicide cults to the God-Machine.

Mystery Cult Initiation reflects membership in one of these esoteric groups. The dot rating dictates standing. One dot is an initiate, two a respected member, three a priest or organizer, four a decision-making leader, five a high priest or founder. If you wish your character to begin play in a cult, work with your Storyteller to develop the details.

Designing a Mystery Cult requires three things, at bare minimum. First is a Purpose. This is the defining reason the cult exists. Usually, it's tied in with the cult's history and recent background. Second is a Relic. This is an item that grounds its members' faith. For example, a piece of the God-Machine, an ancient text bound in human flesh, or the mummified flesh of a saint. The last is a Doctrine. Every cult is defined by its rules and traditions.

In addition to standing, a Mystery Cult Initiation Merit offers benefits at each level of influence. Develop these as well. The following are guidelines; use them to craft your own cults:

- • A Skill Specialty or one-dot Merit pertaining to the lessons taught to initiates.
- •• A one-dot Merit.
- ••• A Skill dot or a two-dot Merit (often a supernatural Merit).
- •••• A three-dot Merit, often supernatural in origin.
- ••••• A three-dot Merit or a major advantage not reflected in game traits.

Parkour (Style, • to •••••)

Prerequisites: Dexterity •••, Athletics ••

Your character is a trained and proficient free-runner. Free-running is the art of moving fluidly through urban environments with complex leaps, bounds, running tricks, and vaulting. This is the type of sport popularized in modern action films, where characters are unhindered by fences, walls, construction equipment, cars, or anything else the city puts in their ways.

Flow (•): Your character reacts instinctively to any obstacles with leaps, jumps, and scaling techniques. When in a foot chase, subtract your Parkour from the successes needed to pursue or evade. Ignore environmental penalties to Athletics rolls equal to your Parkour rating.

Cat Leap (••): Your character falls with outstanding grace. Normally, characters take one level of bashing damage for every ten feet fallen. Every success on a Dexterity + Athletics roll reduces the effective height by ten feet or three meters. However, if the character would take lethal damage from the fall, the Dexterity + Athletics roll will not reduce the damage. Parkour mitigates this limitation. Additionally, add your Parkour rating to the threshold of damage that can be removed through this roll. Parkour will not mitigate damage from a terminal velocity fall.

Wall Run (•••): When climbing, your character can run upward for some distance before having to traditionally climb. Without rolling, your character scales 10 feet + five feet per dot of Athletics as an instant action, rather than the normal 10 feet.

Expert Traceur (••••): Parkour has become second nature for your character. By spending a Willpower point, you may designate one Athletics roll to run, jump, or climb as a rote action (reroll all failed dice once). On any turn you use this ability, you may not apply your character's Defense to oncoming attacks.

Freeflow (•••••): Your character's Parkour is now muscle memory. She can move without thinking in a zen-like state. The character must run for at least a full minute in order to establish Freeflow. Once established, your character is capable of taking Athletics actions reflexively once per turn. By spending a point of Willpower on an Athletics roll in a foot chase, gain three successes instead of three dice.

Resources (• to •••••)

Effect: This Merit reflects your character's disposable income. She might live in an upscale condo, but if her income is tied up in the mortgage and child support payments, she might have little money to throw around. Characters are assumed to have basic necessities without Resources.

The dot rating determines the relative amount of disposable funding the character has available, depending on your particular chronicle's setting. The same amount of money means completely different things in a game set in Silicon Valley compared to one set in the Detroit slums. One dot is a little spending money here and there. Two is a comfortable, middle class wage. Three is a nicer, upper middle class life. Four is moderately wealthy. Five is filthy rich.

Every item has an Availability rating. Once per chapter, your character can procure an item at her Resources level or lower without issue. An item one Availability level above her Resources reduces her effective Resources by one dot for a full month, since she has to rapidly liquidate funds. She can procure items two Availability levels below her Resources without limit (within reason). For example, a character with Resources 4 can procure as many Availability 2 disposable cellphones as she needs.

Retainer (• to •••••)

Effect: Your character has an assistant, sycophant, servant, or follower on whom she can rely. Establish who this companion is and how he was acquired. It may be as simple as a paycheck. He might owe your character his life. However it happened, your character has a hold on him.

A Retainer is more reliable than a Mentor and more loyal than an Ally. On the other hand, a Retainer is a lone person, less capable and influential than the broader Merits.

The Merit's dot rating determines the relative competency of the Retainer. A one-dot Retainer is barely able to do anything of use, such as a pet that knows one useful trick or a homeless old man who does minor errands for food. A three-dot Retainer is a professional in his field, someone capable in his line of work. A five-dot Retainer is one of the best in his class. If he needs to make a roll within his field, double the Retainer dot rating and use it as a dice pool. For anything else use the dot rating as a dice pool.

This Merit can be purchased multiple times to represent multiple Retainers.

Safe Place (• to •••••)

Effect: Your character has somewhere she can go where she can feel secure. While she may have enemies that could attack her there, she's prepared and has the upper hand. The dot rating reflects the security of the place. The actual location, the luxury, and the size are represented by equipment. A one-dot Safe Place might be equipped with basic security systems or a booby trap at the windows and door. A five-dot could have a security crew, infrared scanners at every entrance, or trained dogs. Each place could be an apartment, a mansion or a hidey-hole.

Unlike most Merits, multiple characters can contribute dots to a single Safe Place, combining their points into something greater. A Safe Place gives an Initiative bonus equal to the Merit dots. This only applies to a character with dots invested in the Safe Place.

Any efforts to breach the Safe Place suffer a penalty equal to the Merit dots invested. If the character desires, the Safe Place can include traps that cause intruders lethal damage equal to a maximum of the Merit rating (player's choice as to how much damage a given trap inflicts). This requires that the character has at least a dot in Crafts. The traps may be avoided with a Dexterity + Larceny roll, penalized by the Safe Place dots.

Sleight of Hand (••)

Prerequisite: Larceny •••

Effect: Your character can pick locks and pockets without even thinking about it. She can take one Larceny-based instant action reflexively in a given turn. Her Larceny actions go unnoticed unless someone is trying specifically to catch her.

Staff (• to •••••)

Effect: Your character has a crew of workers or assistants at her disposal. They may be housekeepers, designers, research assistants, animators, ghouls, cheap thugs, or whatever else makes sense. For every dot in this Merit, choose one type of assistant, and one Skill. At any reasonable time, her staff can take actions using that Skill. These actions automatically garner a single success. While not useful in contested actions, this guarantees success on minor, mundane activities. Note that you may have employees without requiring the Staff Merit. Staff simply adds a mechanical advantage for those groups.

Status (• to •••••)

Effect: Your character has standing, membership, authority, control over, or respect from a group or organization. This may reflect official standing or informal respect. No matter the source, your character enjoys certain privileges within that structure.

Each instance of this Merit reflects standing in a different group or organization. Your character may have Status (The Luck Gang) 3, Status (Drag Racing Circuit) 2, and Status (Police) 1. Each affords its own unique benefits. As you increase dot ratings, your character rises in prominence in the relevant group.

Status only allows advantages within the confines of the group reflected in the Merit. Status (Organized Crime) won't help if your character wants an official concealed carry firearms permit, for example.

Status provides a number of advantages.

First, your character can apply her Status to any Social roll with those over which she has authority or sway.

Second, she has access to group facilities, resources, and funding. Dependent on the group, this could be limited by red tape and requisitioning processes. It's also dependent on the resources the particular group has available.

Third, she has pull. If your character knows another character's Mentor, Resources, Retainer, Contacts, or Allies, she can block their usage. Once per chapter, she can stop a single Merit from being used if it's of a lower dot rating than her Status and if it makes sense for her organization to obstruct that type of person's behavior. In our Organized Crime example, if your character knows that the chief of police has Contacts (Criminal Informant), you may opt to block usage by threatening the informant into silence.

Drawback: Status requires upkeep and often regular duties. If these duties are not upheld, Status may be lost. The dots will not be accessible until the character re-establishes her standing. In our Organized Crime example, your character may be expected to pay protection money, offer tribute to a higher authority, or undertake felonious activities.

Striking Looks (• or ••)

Effect: Your character is stunning, alarming, commanding, repulsing, threatening, charming, or otherwise worthy of attention. Determine how your character looks and how people react to that. For one dot, your character gets a +1 die bonus on any Social rolls that would be influenced by his looks. For two dots, the benefit increases to +2. Depending on the particulars, this might influence Expression, Intimidation, Persuasion, Subterfuge, or other rolls.

Drawback: Attention is a double-edged sword. Any rolls to spot, notice, or remember your character gain the same die bonus. Sometimes, your character will draw unwanted attention in social situations. This could cause further complications.

Sympathetic (••)

Effect: Your character is very good at letting others get close. This gives him an edge in getting what he wants. At the beginning of a social maneuvering attempt, you may choose to accept a Condition such as **Leveraged** or **Swooning** in order to immediately eliminate two of the subject's Doors.

Taste (•)

Prerequisite: Crafts •• and a Specialty in Crafts or Expression

Effect: Your character has refined tastes and can identify minor details in fashion, food, architecture, and other forms of artistry and craftsmanship. Not only does this give her an eye for detail, it makes her a center of attention in critical circles. She can appraise items within her area of expertise. With a Wits + Skill roll, depending on the creation in question (Expression for poetry, Crafts for architecture, for example), your character can pick out obscure details about the item that other, less discerning minds would not. For each success, ask one of the following questions, or take a +1 die bonus to any Social rolls pertaining to groups interested in the art assessed for the remainder of the scene.

- What is the hidden meaning in this?
- What was the creator feeling during its creation?
- What's its weakest point?
- What other witness is most moved by this piece?
- How should one best appreciate this piece?

Trained Observer (• or •••)

Prerequisite: Wits ••• or Composure •••

Effect: Your character has spent years in the field, catching tiny details and digging for secrets. She might not have a better chance of finding things, but she has a better chance of finding *important* things. Any time you make a Perception roll (usually Wits + Composure), you benefit from the 9-again quality. With the three-dot version, you get 8-again.

True Friend (•••)

Effect: Your character has a true friend. While that friend may have specific functions covered by other Merits (Allies, Contacts, Retainer, Mentor, et cetera), True Friend represents a deeper, truly trusting relationship that cannot be breached. Unless your character does something egregious to cause it, her True Friend will not betray her. The Storyteller cannot kill a True Friend as part of a plot without your express permission. Any rolls to influence a True Friend against your character suffer a –5 die penalty. In addition, once per story your character can regain one spent Willpower by having a meaningful interaction with her True Friend.

Unseen Sense (••)

Prerequisite: Human character (not Kindred)

Effect: Your character has a "sixth sense" for a type of supernatural creature, chosen when you buy the Merit. For example, you may choose Unseen Sense: Vampires, or Unseen Sense: Fairies. The sense manifests differently for everyone. A character's hair stands on end, she becomes physically ill, or perhaps she has a cold chill. Regardless, she knows that *something isn't right* when she is in the immediate proximity of the appropriate supernatural being. Once per chapter, the player can accept the Spooked Condition (p. 305) in exchange for which the character can pinpoint where the feeling is coming from. If the target is using a power that specifically cloaks its supernatural nature, however, this does not work (though the Condition remains until resolved as usual).